Every twelfth year these three *daru*s are replaced by fresh wood cut from the forest in a complex secret ceremony. As soon as the new mask has been painted on, the three images are treated as living deities. They have their own dedicated staff who wake them, wash them and dress them in a series of outfits and jewellery that are changed as often as eight times a day, with different clothes for every day of the week and special outfits for public dressings, known as *suna besha*, that take place five times a year. Before they are put to bed the images are smeared in sandalwood paste to keep them cool. They are then lodged on a platform in the *garbha griha*, or innermost sanctum of the main temple, from which they are carried out to participate in all the annual festivals. Of these the most important is the annual *ratha yatra* which takes place in June, when they are brought out through the temple's lion gate and placed in their respective chariots, each drawn by long lines of men, to be pulled in procession round the temple and home again.

Similar if less elaborate rituals take place in temples all over India, but what is so strikingly unusual here at Puri is that the three *daru*s have remained deliberately symbolic rather than anthropomorphic. One has to ask why.

One explanation is that the Puri Jagannath was originally a local tribal deity, that these wooden objects echo the original aboriginal worship of wooden totem poles in the forest, and that the myth records a non-tribal ruler winning over the local tribal peoples by accepting their gods. In support of this theory is the fact that the *daru*s have to be cut from particular trees displaying specific auspicious signs in specific wooded areas, with an anthill and water nearby and a snake-hole at the foot of the tree, but no birds nesting or even perching on the tree. Furthermore, the leading role in the finding and shaping of the *daru*s is undertaken by the male members of a tribal community called the Dayitapatis, who are said to be descended from Viswavasu, the first